

The Portaproblem

It's an age old rant, from back in the 90s that persists even now. There's a bit of a porting problem when it comes to PC games. Here's the thing though, we've seen some amazing ports. Grand Theft Auto 5 for instance, or the new Tomb Raider Trilogy, and even the latest God of War game, to name a few. They work flawlessly on PC. One would assume that with excellent examples already in existence, the porting problem wouldn't still persist. But here we are.

The game in question that has prompted this particular editorial is the Wild Hearts PC port. Wild Hearts is a monster hunter title that just released a short while ago. And while we've got the PS5 review in the works, we were hoping for a PC code. We're actually thankful we got the PS5 code instead. If it wasn't obvious enough, the PC port is pretty terrible. You just need to visit Wild Hearts' Steam page to see the top rated review, which is a thumbs down btw, stating that "the price is higher than the FPS you will be able to pull from this game". Of course, the reviewer meant in dollars but you get it.

So what's the deal? Is it really that hard to port a game to PC? We've actually done a cover story on this in the past and it really shouldn't be, especially in today's day and age. Today, developers should already know exactly what features a PC port of a game should have. The essentials of a PC port if you will. Rebindable keys for starters, adjustable aspect ratios and resolutions, unlocked frame rates. Let's not forget about those annoying camera angles as well. Those are the bare minimum that PC gamers would

expect from any PC game, let alone a PC port. There's also the optimisation side of things. I do understand that with consoles the disparity in configurations isn't as vast as in PCs, but performance optimization is essential if you want any kind of PC port to be successful.

This is all freely available knowledge, and like I mentioned earlier, PC ports have already accomplished and find a great balance between both performance and PC-focused features. Heck, some ports - like Death Stranding for NVIDIA DLSS - have even been used to showcase upcoming technology for PC games. Yet, there are still oh so many bad PC ports, so it does kind of baffle the mind.

Maybe something else is the issue? Maybe PC ports were always bad, and it's the hardware dynamic shift that's causing more games to be called out for being a bad PC port. Let me explain, it was easier to get beefier rigs back in the day. Ultimate tier gaming components now cost an arm, a leg and a kidney, so game optimization more important than ever to get decent performance out of more pocket-friendly rigs. Maybe back in the day powerful hardware simply compensated for a poor PC port. But hey, that's a maybe, it might not necessarily be true.

There are enough examples of this not being the case. Gotham Knights was pushing PC hardware to its limits despite looking worse than 2009's Arkham Asylum. Elden Ring is hard-locked to 60 FPS on PC, and still suffers from stuttering problems. Hero Zero Dawn infamously launched in a pretty broken state, although Sony



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has been doing a better job with ports since. Forspoken has been called out for looking worse than its trailers, and it's more demanding than Cyberpunk 2077 despite being a pretty barren open-world game. These are all fairly recent PC ports that had problems. Over time these issues are often ironed out with patches, but is it acceptable to release any game on a platform when it's in such a state?

What would your solution to such a problem be? How can developers iron the kinks in their PC ports before they release them to the public? *